twenty minutes into the second half. The Greeks had been attacking and almost scored, which might have finished us off. Nigel Martyn, in goal, threw the ball out to me, on the left wing. I'm sure Gary was thinking: what's he doing over there? I sort of barged past one player, took another one on and, ten yards outside the corner of their box, the ref gave a foul which probably wasn't. It was too wide of goal for a shot. Teddy Sheringham was just about to come on as a substitute in place of Robbie Fowler. While I was waiting for the changeover, I noticed a piece of red card on the field by the ball. I grabbed it and flung it away from me. I was so frustrated I was blaming our troubles on the litter by then. As Teddy jogged past me, he said:

'Watch me. Just watch me.'

I knew what he meant: we'd played that many games together for United. I lifted the free-kick towards the space I knew Teddy would run into. All he needed was a touch: he knew exactly where the ball was going, beyond their goalkeeper and into the far corner. We were level and back on track for the finals. But for only a minute. We'd hardly finished celebrating before Greece broke away and scored again. *That's it. This isn't going to be our day, is it?*

I was frozen to the spot. I could see other players' shoulders sagging at the same time, the same thoughts running through their minds. We kept going, of course. You have to. But I couldn't see us scoring again. Another couple of free-kicks; another couple wide of the post. Maybe that was why I was running round like I was. The frustration of getting chances with that many free-kicks, seven or eight of them during the game, and not getting a single one on target. It was the last minute and Nigel didn't have time for anything other than a big boot downfield. Teddy went up for it. He did well. I don't know if he really got a shove in the back or not but it was enough to get a foul, five yards outside the Greek penalty area.

I put the ball down. Teddy came over as if to grab it and take the free-kick himself.

'I'll have this.'

I'd missed a few that afternoon but I wasn't going to give this last one up.

'No, Ted. It's too far out for you.'

I don't know why I said that because it wasn't. But Teddy looked up, looked at their wall, and let me get on with it. I knew this was our last chance. I tried to slow my nerves down by blowing out a couple of long breaths.